

Kevin Rouff

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PROFILE

I've spent nearly a decade bringing new technology and materials to skeptical audiences across heavy industry, mining, government and design, across 10+ countries. For six years I co-led a small team with no authority, no resources and nobody to delegate to; I defined the work, won the contracts and delivered them, moving fluidly between the lab, C-suite and factory floor. Yet every engagement ended when the client's did. I'm looking now for work that compounds toward a larger mission, where a role with blurred edges is the job rather than a compromise.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Founder in Residence | *Entrepreneur First* (Talent investor & company-building programme)

Apr - Jul 2026 | London

Developed and stress-tested company theses across AI and heavy industry, from extraction metallurgy and critical minerals to AI infrastructure, validated through techno-economic assessment and expert interviews worldwide. Left the programme to work on the same problems from inside an operating company.

Co-Founder and Director | *ThusThat* (Applied materials R&D & consulting)

2019 - 2026 | Amsterdam

Rio Tinto (Canada / US / Australia):

Multi-year engagement across three continents, coordinating between R&D teams and Corporate Affairs with no formal authority over either. Brokered a partnership with an external startup through to signed MOU, led two RFIs on US Superfund sites, developed a nationwide competition concept from proposal through to launch, and delivered the client's keynote at C2 Montreal on their behalf.

Deployment inside customer organisations:

Scoped and ran engagements end to end across mining and heavy industry (Rio Tinto, Norsk Hydro, Rusal, BEEAH), government (Royal Commission of AlUla), research institutions (KU Leuven) and cultural organisations (Studio Olafur Eliasson). For BEEAH (UAE), built a concept for valorising industrial incineration ash from zero with Swiss manufacturer USM Foundation, developing novel glass, ceramic and cement materials with UK and Belgian labs for scaled architectural demonstration.

Commercial ownership:

Proposals, contracts, budgets, timelines, pitching and client relationships, all run by two people selling into Fortune 500 R&D and procurement functions. Won the work, then ran it.

Technical and executive translation:

Designed and led all material R&D, one patent filed and 5+ custom materials developed for the built environment, then turned it into research reports, roadmaps and presentations for boards, technical specialists and public audiences. Built internal Python tooling for R&D logging, experiment tracking and reporting.

Reach:

25+ speaking engagements (Harvard, Virginia Tech, Arizona State, C2 Montreal); semester-long Guest Professorship at HfG Karlsruhe; 20+ exhibitions across EMEA, Asia and the Americas.

Founders Associate & Head of Product | *AIVA* (A.I.-powered matching platform)

2016 - 2017 | Los Angeles

Business and product lead for an AI matching platform founded by an Argonne National Laboratory researcher, before AI was cool. Owned the product roadmap and UX, pitched investors, and sat between the technical build and the commercial strategy.

Co-Founder | *Rippl* (Consumer tech startup)

2015 - 2016 | San Francisco

Co-founded an online memorial platform. Raised a \$350k seed round; led product, strategy and investor relationships from zero.

EDUCATION

Imperial College London & Royal College of Art | M.Sc. (*Distinction*) + M.A. Innovation Design Engineering, joint, 2019

Stanford University | B.Sc. Science, Technology & Society and B.A. Slavic Languages & Literature, both *Honours*, 2015

Phi Beta Kappa (elected as a junior, 2014) | *President's Award* | *Chappell Lougee* Scholarship

RECOGNITION & LANGUAGES

Awards: Wallpaper* Design of the Year 2021 | Fast Company Innovation by Design 2019 | Dezeen Awards shortlist 2021, 2024

Press: Financial Times, Dezeen, Fast Company, Wallpaper*, AD (DE/ES/RU), IDEAT, Dwell, Frame, DesignBoom

English (native) | French (fluent) | Spanish (conversational) | Russian (conversational)